The Digi-Comp II counter: what the simulation showed

West bay 3: the Digi-Comp II counter · 26 October 2026

1/2 inch steel balls (12.7 mm, 8.35 g), PLA parts, friction 0.3, no bounce, the board at 15 degrees, 2400 steps a second, the pins' friction 0.4 kg cm^2/s^2, unless a line says otherwise. The flip-flop was worked out alone first, with `tests/toggle.lua` (one rocker under its channel, balls let go one at a time, 16 of them), then in the counter, with its tour (eight balls from 0, each reading checked).

The flip-flop

The idea. A rocker on a pin whose centre of mass is up the slope from the pin is over-centre: it falls to one side or the other against a stop and stays, a bit of memory. Its top is a roof whose apex is up the slope from the pin, so the apex leans with it. A ball coming straight down meets the roof beside the apex, on the side that is raised, and its weight on that side takes the rocker over. So each ball goes the other way from the last. The first rocker, an inverted V of plain strips, did this sixteen times out of sixteen at every slope from 6 to 30 degrees and every friction from 0.1 to 0.6, as long as it leaned at least 8 degrees (at 6 degrees the apex moved too little to choose a side for the ball).

Cups. With friction at its pin, the plain roof stopped half way over: the ball runs off the end of the roof while the rocker is still near the middle, where its own weight hardly turns it, and the pin's friction holds it there. The next ball then finds no raised side. At 0.8 kg cm^2/s^2 of pin friction, 14 of 16 balls went the wrong way. A **lip** at each end of the roof makes a cup, which holds the ball until the rocker has gone over; at the end of the swing the cup tips it out. With 5 mm lips the rocker worked at four times that friction. The lips lean out 67 degrees from straight up the slope:

Lips (lean out)	Counter's tour, under 10 hard conditions
none	fails at 0.8 kg cm^2/s^2 of pin friction (the rocker alone)
60 degrees	8 of 10: a ball stays in a cup when the table is tilted 2 degrees across
67 degrees	9 of 10: with no pin friction at all, a rocker bounces back from its stop
75 degrees	9 of 10: the same
3.5 mm long, 67 degrees	8 of 10: too short to hold the ball over at high pin friction

(The ten: tilted 1 and 2 degrees across either way, pin friction 0 and 2, friction 0.1 and 0.6, slope 10 and 20 degrees. These were run with the pin friction first estimated, 0.25 kg cm^2/s^2, before the steel ball below, which these rockers did not have.)

The weight. The bouncing back is a sign that the rocker's two leanings are too shallow: its centre of mass was only 1.5 mm up the slope from the pin, so the dip it rests in is tiny, and a rocker coming hard onto its stop can rebound right out of it. A **steel ball of 1/4 inch (1.04 g)** pressed into the rocker under its apex, 5.8 mm up from the pin, moves the centre of mass to 2.4 mm and makes the dip deep enough: with it and the 67 degree lips, the counter passed all ten (and so did 1 and 2 g, 5 mm up, tried before it).

The apex. The first rockers were built of boxes, and the strut from the pin to the apex stood 3.5 mm above the roof: the ball landed on its corner and went either way. The rocker is now built of convex pieces

whose upper edges are the roof's lines exactly, nothing above them (and the printed part is the same pieces).

Its numbers. Roof 32 mm wide at 30 degrees, apex 10 mm up the slope from the pin, lips 5 mm, strips 3.5 mm, 9 mm high, 1.5 mm off the board on the pin's boss; it leans 12 degrees either way to its stop pegs. It weighs 2.5 g printed solid, 3.6 g with its steel ball.

The pin's friction. The rocker lies on the boss round its pin with its weight across the board, 3.4 g-force; PLA on PLA (0.3 to 0.4) at the boss's mean radius (about 2.9 mm) gives about 0.4 kg cm^2/s^2 (0.04 mN m), the pin itself a tenth of that. The simulation uses 0.4. At that, the rocker's own weight cannot turn it against the pin when it is near its stop (about 0.03 at 8 degrees), so it stays where the ball leaves it, 8 to 12 degrees over: that is still far enough for the next ball to choose its side.

The rocker alone (`tests/toggle.lua`, 16 balls each; the least lean any ball left it at):

	Passed	Least lean
as built	yes	9.1 degrees
pin friction 0, 1, 2, 4, 5	yes	11.6, 11.0, 10.3, 3.8, 0.5
pin friction 6	**no**: the rocker stops in the middle	1.3
friction 0.1 to 0.8	yes	7.8 to 9.8
slope 6 to 30 degrees	yes	9.6 to 11.6
run 5, 10, 15 cm longer (faster balls)	yes	7.6, 6.0, 2.8
run 20 cm longer	**no**: the ball comes too fast and jumps the cup	
let go up to 0.75 mm off centre (all the channel allows)	yes	8.7
tilted across 2 or 3 degrees one way, 2 the other	yes	7.1 to 10.0
tilted across 3 degrees the other way, or 4	**no**	
1200 and 4800 steps a second	yes	8.8, 9.9

Tilted across, the ball runs down its channel pressed against the downhill wall, and the board's sideways pull carries it past the apex onto the low side, which it then rolls down without turning the rocker. So the board must be level across: within 2 degrees.

The counter

The staircase. Each flip-flop 3.5 cm left of and 8 cm below the last, so a carry leaving the left cup falls straight into the next one's funnel; each done ball leaves the right cup into a lane straight down to the bins. The lanes' mouths were first 2.4 cm right of the pin: a ball came out of the cup and stuck, wedged between the rocker's lip and the lane's flared wall (found with `DC_CONTACTS`). At 2.8 cm they clear.

The feeder. A wheel of four notches turning under the channel of balls. Three things were found:

- A wall's box runs 1.5 mm past its ends (so walls meet solidly), and the ends of the channels at the wheel's housing reached into the wheel's path: the wheel rubbed them and stuck at friction 0.5. Those channels now start 2 mm further out.
- The hand must be able to push: seven waiting balls press on the wheel's rim. The simulation's hand turns the knob with up to 50 kg cm^2/s^2 (5 mN m, a light finger); it also passed with 20 and 1000.
- In the first wheel the teeth only touched the hub, which would have printed as five pieces: the hub is now 0.5 mm wider than the notches, so the wheel is one solid.

The tour, eight balls from 0, each reading and each ball's bin checked, the machine as built (pin friction 0.4), passed in every one of these:

- friction 0.1, 0.2, 0.3, 0.4, 0.5, 0.6
- pin friction 0, 1, 2, 3 (eight times the estimate)
- slope 8, 10, 15, 20, 25 degrees
- 1200, 2400, 4800 steps a second
- tilted across 1 and 2 degrees either way
- friction 0.6 with: tilted 2 degrees either way, slope 10 degrees, pin friction 2; friction 0.1 with: tilted 1 degree either way or 2 one way, slope 10 degrees, no pin friction
- the hand's torque 20 and 1000

and failed at pin friction 4 (a rocker stopped near the middle), tilted 3 degrees across either way, and at friction 0.1 tilted 2 degrees the other way. So: level across within 2 degrees, and within 1 to be sure.

What it costs

Little: eight balls, three rockers and the wheel, against some fifty fixed walls and pegs. The tour, about 28 simulated seconds, took 7 s of computing headless here; the exhibit rests (stops stepping) once nothing has moved for half a second.

What is idealised

- The knob is turned by the hand: a motor on the wheel's pin, exactly a quarter turn at a time. In the machine as built you turn it by its four marks (how far off a quarter it may be was not tried).
- The pins are hinges with a constant friction torque.
- Setting it back puts the balls and the rockers in place by hand.